

The Sin Unto Death and the Life Given for a Brother

Go to 1 John 5, and let us see what we can pick up. Hallelujah.

There are a few very difficult verses in here, but they are so powerful that it is a shame to let them go into the land of no understanding.

One time when I was asking God, I slipped into the Spirit, and it was the first time I ever saw the born-again trail. I used to say that often, but I made myself stop. I was seeking God, and all of a sudden I was looking down this born-again trail. That is the only way I could explain it.

One woman asked me right after that happened, "What are you going to teach on in the early service?"

I said, "The born-again trail."

She said, "Yeah, right. Very funny."

But I actually got to look down this path and saw where it would bring you, what had happened to you. The Holy Spirit came to bring power to that, not replace it.

As I looked down that path, I said, "God, this is incredible. Since You are communicating with me, there are some verses I have always wanted to ask You about. Where does the discovery of Your power lie? Those things that really move You, where do we really find them?"

His answer was, "In most of the verses you leave out."

I said, "Why?"

He said, "Because you do not understand them."

Then He said, "Indeed, you will find what you are looking for on this trail."

He was right. Some verses that I considered just passages, verses you pass over, changed my whole life.

John lived probably more than a hundred years. Besides the Gospel, his recorded testimony of the life of Jesus Christ, what do we have? Five chapters in First John, and Second and Third John, which look like half chapters. This man lived all that time and had all that wisdom, and he captured so much of it in these five chapters. It is incredible that we scan through it and barely acknowledge the hundred years that went into it.

John probably walked in more love than any of them. Peter would admit that. John seemed to have an understanding of it. He says all kinds of things about our walk and ties them together with the love of God. From my background, that was hard to understand. But now some of the books I

avoided in the beginning, I cannot put down.

First John 5:15 says:

And if we know that he hear us,
whatsoever we ask,
we know that we have the petitions that we desired of him.

Then verse 16:

If any man see his brother sin a sin which is not unto death,
he shall ask,
and he shall give him life for them that sin not unto death.
There is a sin unto death:
I do not say that he shall pray for it.

Then he explains himself as though it helped:

All unrighteousness is sin:
and there is a sin not unto death.

Then verse 18 says:

We know that whosoever is born of God sinneth not.

Really?

We do not have time to cover all of that, but we can begin with this:

If any man see his brother sin a sin which is not unto death,
he shall ask,
and he shall give him life for them that sin not unto death.

It is hard to understand that verse until you understand what the sin unto death is. John says, "I do not say that you shall pray for that." But the good news is this: if you see your brother sinning a sin that is not unto death, it is still sin and it is still destroying him. He should not have it in his life. But you can ask God, and somehow God is able to give you life for him.

I understand that now, but I did not before I discovered the place called Done. When people come and want prayer for somebody along these lines, sometimes I have to tell them, "Hang on. You are asking for this, so you are going to have to trust Him, because He is going to start moving."

That box is full of names of people who were not born again or who had all kinds of problems, and many of them are born again now. In the testimonies we heard, God moved on their behalf because somebody dropped their name in there and received life for them.

Whenever I see an ambulance, I cannot help it. I was riding with Tim and Leah and said, "That man does not know Jesus, and he will not die until he does." That is all I had to say. I knew God would follow it.

How do I know? Because I received that much life on his behalf. If he dies, he will get a visitation somewhere in there where Jesus arrests him and explains His mission and why He came.

John says if somebody is living a life like that, I can pray and receive from the Father life on that person's behalf. That sin is not going to destroy him. It is not going to stay in his life.

Go to Luke 11. There is no good place to start, so let us start with verse 1:

And it came to pass, that, as he was praying in a certain place,
when he ceased, one of his disciples said unto him,
Lord, teach us to pray,
as John also taught his disciples.

They wanted to know how to pray. Jesus taught them what we call the Lord's Prayer:

Our Father which art in heaven,
Hallowed be thy name.
Thy kingdom come.
Thy will be done, as in heaven, so in earth.
Give us day by day our daily bread.
And forgive us our sins;
for we also forgive every one that is indebted to us.
And lead us not into temptation;
but deliver us from evil.

The Lord's Prayer is a prerequisite for petitionary prayer. That is why He says the things He says: forgive us our sins as we forgive everyone indebted to us; deliver us from the snares of the evil one; meet our needs; let Your will be done in earth as in heaven, especially in my life and in what You have called me to do.

Then He continued teaching:

Which of you shall have a friend,
and shall go unto him at midnight,
and say unto him,
Friend, lend me three loaves;
For a friend of mine in his journey is come to me,
and I have nothing to set before him?
And he from within shall answer and say,
Trouble me not:
the door is now shut,
and my children are with me in bed;
I cannot rise and give thee.
I say unto you,
Though he will not rise and give him, because he is his friend,
yet because of his importunity he will rise and give him as many as he needeth.

We have often painted the man behind the door as God. We have said, "You have to beat on God's door. Use importunity. Stay on Him until He finally gets up and gives you bread for your friend."

We are wrong. I painted it that way at one time, but I have a new brush now.

The man behind the door is the exact opposite of God. God needed an opposite to show you what He is really like. They asked Jesus to teach them on prayer, and He painted a picture of the opposite of God so they could fully understand what God would do with their prayer.

Do not think it is by accident that the man came totally unselfishly. "I do not want the food for myself. I need it for a friend." But the character of the man behind the door is opposite the character of God.

The subject is still this: I want to go to God and ask Him to do something for you. I want to receive something done on your behalf.

Many people have used the end of this passage, "How much more shall your heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to them that ask Him," to get people filled with the Holy Ghost. I have gotten people filled by reading that verse too. But that is not exactly what Jesus was talking about.

He says:

I say unto you,
Ask, and it shall be given you;
seek, and ye shall find;
knock, and it shall be opened unto you.
For every one that asketh receiveth;
and he that seeketh findeth;
and to him that knocketh it shall be opened.

Then He says:

If a son shall ask bread of any of you that is a father,
will he give him a stone?
or if he ask a fish, will he for a fish give him a serpent?
Or if he shall ask an egg, will he offer him a scorpion?
If ye then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children:
how much more shall your heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to them that ask him?

Matthew records it this way:

How much more shall your Father which is in heaven give good things to them that ask him?

Jesus was not only talking about somebody being filled with the Holy Spirit. He was contrasting the reluctant man behind the door with the Father. That man only gave because of inconvenience, but Jesus says, "Ask, and I will give. Seek, and you will find. Knock, and it will be opened."

In particular, when I am there on behalf of somebody else, I can ask: "I need You to give me life on behalf of this person. I see my brother sinning a sin not unto death, and I need You to give me Your power and Your life on his behalf."

If the Holy Spirit can usher His power in there, I guarantee that person is not going to stay the same.

When people ask me, "Will you pray for somebody? They need prayer badly," I say, "Hold on. This is not an afterthought. Let us center on this for a minute. You want God to do something. I do not do that without believing it. Are you ready for something to happen?"

The Holy Spirit is going to be administered here in His power, so something is going to happen.

Sometimes, when faith rises, He likes to harvest the moment. He sees the service almost as if the person were there and He were ministering directly to them, because all He needs is somebody to pray the Lord of the harvest. Then somebody will go there.

You do not know why doctors move to Alaska. It may be to get next to your backslidden doctor son. People are transferred and moved all over because somebody prayed the Lord of the harvest. You gave heaven what it needed to move in on him.

He waits for opportunities like this. He is not ignoring you. How much more shall your heavenly Father give?

Are you ready? You know them in your heart. You have their names. You have a profile of them. He is reading it.

Set yourself in agreement with what I say:

Father God, in the name of Jesus, every person represented here who is holding somebody before You, I ask You as Lord of the harvest. You are the One who paid the price, and You live for these moments.

Father, on their behalf, I receive life for them. I receive life on their behalf. I ask You to take this authority that we are accessing heaven with. Already, Father, if I could hear in the Spirit right now, I am sure I would hear angels' wings, because before we are done with this prayer, they will already be in position, keeping them alive until they are saved.

I have received answered prayer on behalf of others who may not know Him or who do not know Him very well. Father, in Jesus' name, thank You for the testimonies that will come out of this. We give You all the praise, honor, and glory.

Everybody said amen.

One time we prayed a prayer like that, and a cell phone rang. The person they were praying for got saved or something. They said, "My land, that was fast."

Hallelujah.

Let us go back to John and pick on it a little more.

I hope I can teach you into believing who you are. You do not want to wait as long as I did to have one whale of a time. When He says I do not even have to consider the evil of tomorrow, I know what He is talking about now. I know the rest and peace He means.

These are some of my favorite verses:

My peace I give unto you:
not as the world giveth, give I unto you.

What more would I need?

He says:

Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me;
for I am meek and lowly in heart:
and ye shall find rest unto your souls.

When we think of a yoke, we think of a big ox yoked to a little ox, dragging the little ox up and down the road until the little ox learns to plow. But Jesus tells you what the yoke is: "Yoke yourself to Me and learn of Me. You will find I am meek and lowly, and you will find rest for your souls."

He can carry a heavier load than you can. Put it down.

Casting all your care upon him;
for he careth for you.

Notice He loved you first. He is not saying, "Because you loved Me first, cast this on Me." Cast the whole of your care on Him because He cares for you.

Be sober, be vigilant;
because your adversary the devil, as a roaring lion,
walketh about, seeking whom he may devour.

He is looking for people full of care, because that is what makes you devourable. No wonder God said to get rid of it. You resist the devil by getting rid of the care.

Do you not love Him? You should. He unconditionally loved you when you were an old sinner and paid a horrific price for you. He crossed the void of spiritual death. Before He did that, you could stand on the edge of that void and beg Him to save you, and He could not.

That was mercy. That is the difference between mercy and grace. Mercy sent Him across the void. Then He shed His blood so that, because of His mercy, you could pick up His grace, walk over to the void, and say, "Can You save me now?"

He says, "Yes, I can."

When Jesus said, "Be ye therefore merciful, as your Father also is merciful," what do you think He was talking about in Luke 6 leading up to Luke 6:38?

Give, and it shall be given unto you;
good measure, pressed down, and shaken together, and running over,
shall men give into your bosom.

We have all heard that during an offering. But leading up to it, He said:

Be ye therefore merciful, as your Father also is merciful.
Judge not, and ye shall not be judged:
condemn not, and ye shall not be condemned:
forgive, and ye shall be forgiven:
give, and it shall be given unto you.

Then at the end of the chapter He says the man who hears His sayings and does them dug deep and found the rock. He built his house on the rock. The deep digging had to be into His Word.

The sayings began where Jesus said, "I say unto you." If somebody slaps you on the cheek, turn the other one. If he steals your goods, give. If they spitefully use you, pray for them. If they hate you, do good to them.

When He capped that teaching with "Be merciful, as your Father is merciful," He was asking you to extend the blood of Jesus across that void to lost people. No matter what it costs you to do that, that is where He picks up the bill in Luke 6:38 and gives it all back to you, good measure, pressed down, shaken together, and running over.

Back to 1 John 5:16:

If any man see his brother sin a sin which is not unto death,
he shall ask,
and he shall give him life for them that sin not unto death.
There is a sin unto death:
I do not say that he shall pray for it.

The guy sinning the sin unto death seems like the one who needs prayer worse. But who is this man, and what is the sin?

Go back to 1 John 4:1:

Beloved, believe not every spirit,
but try the spirits whether they are of God:
because many false prophets are gone out into the world.
Hereby know ye the Spirit of God:
Every spirit that confesseth that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is of God:
And every spirit that confesseth not that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is not of God:
and this is that spirit of antichrist.

In my ultra-holiness days, we used this when casting out devils. We would hold somebody down and say, "Did Jesus come in the flesh?" Sometimes the devil would say yes, and that mixed us up.

John was not mainly talking about demons. He was talking about false prophets, those coming and teaching another Jesus. They did not have web pages and Bibles in their hands. Many could not read. False teachers and merchandisers were rampant, preaching another Jesus.

John says any spirit that confesses not that God was manifested in Jesus Christ, that He came in the flesh and was crucified and died for our sins, is antichrist.

When those men preached, the sin they committed was a sin unto death because they were taking the crucifixion out of the message. Everyone who followed them in their doctrine would be receiving the teaching of another prophet who denied that Jesus Christ was God in the flesh.

In Second John he says:

For many deceivers are entered into the world,
who confess not that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh.
This is a deceiver and an antichrist.
Look to yourselves,
that we lose not those things which we have wrought,
but that we receive a full reward.
Whosoever transgresseth,
and abideth not in the doctrine of Christ,
hath not God.
He that abideth in the doctrine of Christ,
he hath both the Father and the Son.
If there come any unto you,
and bring not this doctrine,
receive him not into your house,
neither bid him God speed:
For he that biddeth him God speed
is partaker of his evil deeds.

That is what First John 5 came out of. Anybody coming and preaching that doctrine was not someone you were to bless in his journey. You could pray for his eyes to be opened and for him to come to the truth, but you could not pray God's speed over a journey when it was not God he was preaching.

These men preaching an all-inclusive message that tells people they are okay when they are not are committing a sin unto death. That is the death part John was talking about. The sin unto death delivers people to death because it takes Jesus crucified out of the message.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

All right. I did it.

Did anybody have a good time? I did. Stand up. I had a really good time tonight.

Let us worship Him for a moment, and then I will let you go.